

CLASS MATERIAL

WEEK 1

CEL2103 WRITING ACADEMIC TEXTS
SEMESTER 2, 2024-2025

Introduction to Comparison and Contrast Essay

- Purpose of compare and contrast essay
- Structure of compare and contrast essay
 - Block organisation
 - Point-by-point organisation

Purpose of Comparison and Contrast Essay

A comparison and contrast essay is a type of essay that explains the similarities and differences between the subjects. Comparison in writing describes traits that are similar while contrast in writing describes traits that are different.

Activity 1

Below are sample paragraphs from various types of essays. Read the texts and identify which paragraphs are from a compare and contrast essay. Then answer the questions that follow.

Paragraph 1

The film previews are finished, and the movie theatre is quiet as everyone waits for the feature film to begin. However, the stillness is suddenly broken by a noise. The audience hears a snuffle. The snuffle soon turns to a cry, then a wail. There is an uncomfortable, or perhaps unhappy, toddler sitting in the movie theatre. People start shuffling in their seats as they wait for what will happen next. Will the child be taken out of the theatre, or will the parents pretend that everything is fine? Scenarios like these happen regularly. The parents' reaction depends on their parenting style. Two extremes are the lenient parents and the strict disciplinarian parents. Lenient parents want their children to have fun and enjoy "being a kid". They are not concerned with time-based activities, and they will allow their kids to stay up late and experience new things. However, disciplinarian parents monitor their children very carefully since their main priorities are safety and protection. While these parenting styles seem like polar opposite of each other, both styles share a similarity where they are influenced by factors such as situations and environment.

Paragraph 2

If a person suffers from shyness, he or she is not alone, for shyness is a universal phenomenon. According to recent research, "close to 50 percent of the general population reported that they currently experience some degree of shyness in their lives. In addition, close to 80 percent reported having felt shy at some point in their lives" (Payne, 2011). As shyness is so common, it is not surprising that social scientists are learning more about its causes. They have found that shyness can result from both biological and environment factors.

Paragraph 3

Some years ago, people were intimidated by the idea of smartphone. For one, smartphone technology was so new that many people were not convinced by it. It was also extremely expensive, and many users were not sure if these phones are worth the price. Today, there are two main options for users who want to own a smartphone. They need to do some research before purchasing one in order to own a smartphone that suits their lifestyle. One of the biggest considerations for a smartphone purchase is iOS or Android. Android, which is Linux-based and partly open source, is more PC-like than iOS, in that its interface and basic features are generally more customisable from top to bottom. However, iOS' uniform design elements are sometimes seen as being more user-friendly. To reach a decision, buyers can compare these two operating systems in terms of their overall cost, convenience and style.

Paragraph 4

Various writers have argued that people who were born around the end of the twentieth century (1990 – 2005) and who have been using computers all their lives have different abilities and needs to other people. Palfrey and Gasser (2008) refer to them as the 'net generation' and argue that activities such as putting videos on YouTube are more natural for them than writing an essay. Similarly, Prensky (2001) claims that the educational system needs to be revised to cater for the preferences of these 'digital natives'. However, other researchers doubt that these claims can apply to a whole generation. Bennett, Maton and Kervin (2008) argue that the 'digital native' theory is a myth and that it would be a mistake to reorganise the educational system and abandon traditional means of assessment to cater for their supposed requirements.

1. Which paragraphs are taken from a compare and contrast essay?
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
2. What are the words used to show that these paragraphs are taken from a compare and contrast essay?
 - a. _____
 - b. _____
3. From the sample paragraphs of compare and contrast essay that you have identified above, what is a compare and contrast essay?

Structure of Compare and Contrast Essay

Activity 2

Based on the outlines provided in the table below, compare the outlines and describe the feature of block organisation and point-by-point organisation in the blank space provided.

BLOCK ORGANISATION	POINT-BY-POINT ORGANISATION
•	•
Paragraph 1: Introduction Two solid options for data storage, namely cloud data storage and traditional storage, have features that are both similar and different. Paragraph 2 (Similarity): Effective - Both have high reliability - Both are easily accessible Paragraph 3 (Difference): Cost - Low for cloud data storage - High for traditional storage Paragraph 4: Conclusion	Paragraph 1: Introduction Two solid options for data storage, namely cloud data storage and traditional storage, have features that are both similar and different. Paragraph 2 (Similarity and Difference): Effective - Cloud data storage - Traditional storage Paragraph 3 (Similarity and Difference): Cost - Cloud data storage - Traditional storage Paragraph 4: Conclusion

NOTE:

Although both organisation methods have equal advantages, in CEL2103 course, you are required to apply **block organisation** in your writing tasks.

Activity 3

Read the model essay below and answer the questions that follow.

A Comparison and Contrast on Population of The United States and Russia

¹Besides being the world's two biggest nuclear superpowers, the United States and Russia also share great interest in nuclear safety and security, counter-terrorism and space exploration. ²Despite all these, the two nations have always maintained unique and challenging foreign relations in the world. ³As many people are aware, there are significant differences between Russia and the United States in their history and form of government. ⁴The United States is a young country with a long history of democratic government. ⁵Russia is a country with ancient roots that has experienced different kinds of government. ⁶However, there are other areas in which the similarity and difference between these two countries could influence their relations. ⁷The United States and Russia are similar in population diversity, but they have different population growth.

⁸One common similarity between the United States and Russia is their population diversity. ⁹The United States and Russia have relatively diverse populations. ¹⁰They both have a majority racial group that constitutes about 80 percent of the population and several significant minority groups (CIA World Factbook, 2011). ¹¹Like the United States, Russia also has linguistic minorities, and there are parts of both countries in which it is common to see signs in two or more languages. ¹²In addition, the United States and Russia are also similar in religious diversity. ¹³Although both countries' populations are largely Christian, they also both have religious minorities such as Muslim, Jews and other small groups of religious minorities (Jackson, 2015).

¹⁴Despite being similar in their population diversity, the United States and Russia are very different in terms of population growth. ¹⁵Russia's population has been shrinking because the birth rate is fairly low although it has increased in recent years. ¹⁶On the other hand, the fertility rate in the United States has been consistently high with 2.06 children compared to only 1.6 for Russia (CIA World Factbook, 2011). ¹⁷Moreover, there is comparatively little immigration to Russia mostly from countries that were once part of the former Soviet Union. ¹⁸In the United States, on the other hand, immigration adds 2.3 million people per year (O'neil, 2013). ¹⁹This consequently contributes to the rapid population growth of the United States.

²⁰In conclusion, while the United States and Russia are different in terms of population growth, they have similar population diversity. ²¹Both countries are home to diverse races and religions. ²²On the contrary, contrasting fertility rate and immigration trends lead to difference in their population growth. ²³These significant similarity and difference indicate the needs for

these countries to cooperate in the international arena. ²⁸It will be interesting to see how the United States and Russia work together in the future.

Adapted from Oshima, A, Hogue, A. and Ravitch, L. (2014). *Longman Academic Writing Series 4: Paragraphs to Essays*, Fifth Edition. New York: Pearson Education

1. What is the purpose of this essay?

2. What are the two things (main ideas) about the United States and Russia does this essay compare?

a. _____

b. _____

3. What type of organisation method is used in the model essay?

4. Which paragraph discusses similarity?

5. What is the difference between the United States and Russia? Which paragraph discusses the difference of the United States and Russia?

6. List the words that are used to show comparison and contrast

a. _____

f. _____

b. _____

g. _____

c. _____

h. _____

d. _____

i. _____

e. _____

j. _____